

Avicenna and the flying man



Aristotelian philosophy and science thrived during the Islamic ‘Golden Age’. Baghdad and Damascus in particular became centres of intellectual activity, attracting philosopher-scientists including al-Kindi and al-Farabi. In Persia, Ibn Sina, known in the West as Avicenna, was known as a pioneering physician, but also an important philosopher and theologian. Although he had studied Aristotle, he was also influenced by Plato and the idea of dualism – that there is a realm of immaterial things separate from the world we live in. Avicenna developed the idea of dualism further, arguing that our senses and reason, corresponding to our body and mind, are

similarly distinct. He illustrated this with the image of a 'flying man', blindfolded and floating in the air, effectively deprived of all his senses. Despite receiving no information from his senses, he is still aware that he has a 'self' or 'soul' that exists but has no physical substance. The mind and body coexist, but are distinct; the mind or soul exists in the realm of immaterial things and so is not destroyed when the physical body dies.